

Establish a Precise Claim

Your introduction should conclude with a sentence that conveys your thesis by indicating three persuasive devices the author uses to build his or her argument. Here are three examples:

1. The author crafts a persuasive and compelling argument by recalling a memorable personal anecdote, addressing a counterargument, and providing an array of facts and statistics.
2. The author builds a persuasive argument by appealing to the reader's sense of injustice, emphasizing logical artistic benefits, and addressing a prevalent counterargument.
3. The authors build a convincing argument by documenting their claim with facts and statistics, pointing out logical benefits, and making use of a subtle appeal to the readers' emotional affinity for preserving natural habitats.

These three concluding examples do more than just present the author's precise central claim. They also use parallel structure to demonstrate stylistic variation, and employ strong, precise vocabulary such as *compelling*, *prevalent*, *array*, and *affinity*.

The full impact of each example becomes clear when it is combined with other sentences to create a full introductory paragraph. Special thanks to Julia Garaffa and Ben Yao for sharing excerpts from their outstanding essays!

Introduce Each Body Paragraph

The College Board scoring rubric rewards essays that contain "a highly effective progression of ideas." The phrase "progression of ideas" refers to the way you introduce each of your three body paragraphs. This often-overlooked feature is an important characteristic of an advanced essay. Our experience indicates that readers will reward essays that include skillful transitional sentences.

How to Begin Your First Body Paragraph

Now that you have written a skillful introduction, your next task is to provide your College Board readers with a strong sentence introducing your first body paragraph. Here are three examples:

1. Klinenberg begins his argument by recounting a personal experience with the problems caused by excessive use of air-conditioning.
2. Hitchens begins crafting a convincing argument by providing important background information about the damages inflicted upon the Parthenon.
3. Fitzpatrick and Fenwick begin by providing a series of alarming statistics about plummeting bird populations across the Midwest.

All three of these examples utilize a topic sentence that clearly introduces the persuasive argument to be discussed in the first body paragraph. Note that the authors avoid cliché opening lines such as *For their first argument...* or *Let's begin by discussing...*

How to Begin Your Second Body Paragraph

Creating a highly effective transition from your first to your second body paragraph requires an advanced level of writing. Here are three generic examples that you can use in any essay:

1. The author continues his/her line of argumentation by presenting a series of pertinent facts and statistics.
2. The author now disarms his/her critics by addressing a widespread counterargument.
3. The authors further enhance their argument by outlining the benefits of following their recommended policy and the drawbacks of ignoring it.

These three generic examples all use a strong active voice to introduce the author's second persuasive argument. Note the use of precise words such as *pertinent* (relevant), *disarm*, and *enhance*.

How to Begin Your Third Body Paragraph

Transitional sentences are the glue that connects your ideas. Writing an advanced five-paragraph essay requires a toolbox filled with great transitional sentences. Don't worry—we are up to the challenge! Here are three generic examples that will enable you to make a smooth transition to your third and final body paragraph:

1. The author does more than just cite authorities and appeal to his/her reader's emotions; he/she also uses statistical evidence to document the imperative need for the public to support...
2. The author does more than just recount a personal story and address a counterclaim; he/she also makes a strong logical case for supporting...
3. The author is not content to build an argument that relies exclusively on objective facts and logic; he/she concludes by making a direct appeal to the reader's sense of justice.

These three examples all provide the College Board readers with a bridge connecting the previous two body paragraphs with the final body paragraph.

Note that while these examples are not stuffed with "ten-dollar" words, they do make use of moderately sophisticated terms that give the writing less of a typical "high school" feel. For instance, the first example uses *imperative* rather than *urgent*; the second example uses *recount* rather than *tell*; and the third example uses *exclusively* rather than *only*. In all cases, however, the use of these types of terms is restrained—it is not intended to show off the writer's vocabulary but rather to indicate that the writer understands the conventions of academic writing.

Note also that all three examples utilize a variety of complex sentence structures that demonstrate advanced writing ability. Each option begins by referring to a previously discussed persuasive device (e.g. citing authorities and appealing to the reader's emotion) in order to more effectively emphasize that the author employs other forms of persuasion as well. This strategy of "referring back" creates a sense of flow and continuity within the essay—a key component of cohesiveness.

Write a Skillful Conclusion

The College Board rubric for an advanced Level 8 Writing score requires a skillful conclusion. Your conclusion should not contain new information. Instead, it should reinforce your thesis.

Your First Sentence

This sentence should provide a brief restatement of the author's claim. Here are three examples:

1. Klinenberg offers his readers a cogent argument to support measures that reduce our wasteful reliance on air-conditioning.
2. Hitchens voices a compelling argument to persuade his readers that the British Museum should return the original Parthenon sculptures to Greece.
3. Fitzpatrick and Fenwick offer convincing arguments why their readers should support the Conservation Reserve Program.

These three examples all perform the required task of providing a precise summary of the author or author's central claim. Note how the first example slips in an excellent vocabulary word, *cogent*, in a very subtle and appropriate way.

Your Final Sentence

The finish line is now just one sentence away! Now is the time to leave your two College Board readers with a strong concluding sentence that demonstrates your skillful command of writing. Here are three examples:

1. He accomplishes this feat of building a convincing argument by recalling a memorable personal anecdote to establish a connection with his readers, addressing a counterargument to persuade skeptics, and providing key facts and statistics to substantiate his claim.
2. He builds a compelling argument by appealing to his reader's emotions to evoke a sense of outrage, emphasizing artistic benefits to persuade open-minded readers, and addressing a counterargument to demonstrate that he understands all sides of a complex issue.
3. The co-authors make a forceful case by using statistics to document the growing peril faced by wildlife, underscoring key benefits to persuade cost-conscious critics, and appealing to emotions to evoke a feeling of responsibility to preserve natural habitats.

These concluding sentences all summarize the key points developed in the essay's body paragraphs. They do this by using parallel structure to reiterate how each argument affects the readers.

Precise Word Choice

As we've seen, the SAT Essay scoring rubric rewards writing that "demonstrates a consistent use of precise word choice." Precise word choice means using a strong descriptive vocabulary that clearly expresses and defines your thoughts.

College Board readers will not be impressed if you use too many big words, so don't overdo it by being bombastic (overblown). Instead, try to include well-chosen descriptive words that are neither too casual nor too formal. So while you shouldn't start throwing around terms like *reprobate* or *recondite*, you should also avoid words like *things* and *awesome*. (Recall that SAT Writing passages are designed to emphasize this type of writing as well.)

Students often make the mistake of using words they don't fully understand, or that are too extreme for a particular situation. For example, one student described former President Clinton as a "revered" authority. While President Clinton is a knowledgeable leader, he is not considered someone who deserves the type of respect that borders on worship. The incorrect use of words like *revered* is a red flag that will catch your reader's attention and possibly cost you a point. As a general rule, if you aren't 100% of how a word should be used, you should avoid including it altogether.

Keep in mind that passages are written by established authors who typically present reasoned arguments using restrained language. These articles do not generally lend themselves to essays using extreme words such as *amazing*, *horrific*, or *atrocious*. Instead, they support the use of moderate words such as *cogent*, *discerning*, and *pivotal*.

You must also be careful to avoid too much repetition. While the Essay assignment requires that you consistently refer back to the author or authors' points, you should make sure to vary the way in which you introduce those points. For example, you do not want to rely excessively on the verbs *say*, *state*, and *tell* (e.g. *At the end of the introduction, the author states... In the second paragraph, the author says...*). Instead, you should also try to include an array of precise verbs such as *conveys*, *illustrates*, *implies*, *(re)affirms*, or *recounts*.

The list that begins on the following page includes 25 carefully chosen descriptive words and pairs of synonyms that students have successfully used in their essays. We define each word and then provide you with a generic sentence that can be adapted to most essays.

Top Essay Words

1. **Alleviate** – to lessen, mitigate, assuage
The author believes that his/her proposal will begin **alleviating** a serious problem.
2. **Assert(ion)** – claim
The author supports this **assertion** by using statistics to bolster his/her argument.
3. **Audacious** – showing great boldness
Aware that timid solutions will not fully address the problem, the author proposes an **audacious** plan of action.
4. **Buttress, Bolster** – to support, strengthen
The author uses an array of statistical evidence to **buttress/bolster** his/her argument that...
5. **Cogent** – convincing, persuasive, forceful
The author crafts a **cogent** argument designed to convince his/her readers to support...
6. **Convey** – indicate, make clear
The author **conveys** a sense of urgency by making a strong appeal to the reader's emotions.
7. **Credibility** – believability, reliability
The author establishes his/her **credibility** by citing a variety of reputable sources.
8. **Discerning** – demonstrating keen insight
The author's **discerning** analysis underscores his/her use of logic to address a difficult issue.
9. **Eminent** – well-known, prominent, renowned
The author cites an **eminent** authority to buttress his/her argument that...
10. **Empathy** – a feeling of great compassion, the ability to put oneself in another person's shoes
The author's personal anecdote activates the reader's sense of **empathy** towards the human drama expressed by the author.
11. **Enumerate** – provide a list of
The author **enumerates** the advantages of this possibility by using a variety of persuasive devices.
12. **Evenhanded** – fair to all sides
The author's **evenhanded** presentation of the counterargument demonstrates his/her lack of extreme bias.
13. **Evoke, Elicit** – produce, call forth
The alarming lack of financial support for space technology is designed to **evoke/elicit** a sense of urgency among readers.
14. **Idealist(ic)** – a person who presents things as they should be rather than as they are
The author is not an impractical **idealist**; instead, he/she is a pragmatist committed to offering the public practical solutions to difficult problems.

15. **Imperative** – necessary and urgent
The author concludes by explaining why it is **imperative** that the public support his/her program of action.
16. **Pertinent** – relevant
The author uses **pertinent** data to pinpoint the true dimensions of the problem.
17. **Pivotal** – decisive, critical
The author convincingly demonstrates that we are at a **pivotal** point in our effort to...
18. **Poignant** – touching, heartrending, very sad
The author's **poignant** personal story is intended to elicit a sympathetic response from the reader.
19. **Pragmatic, Prudent** – practical, realistic
The author is a **pragmatic/prudent** leader who is committed to offering a realistic solution to a complex problem.
20. **Ramifications** – the consequences of an action or event
According to the author, the **ramifications** of taking no action will have a number of serious consequences.
21. **Reaffirm** – to make a renewed commitment to do something
The author concludes by calling upon the public to **reaffirm** its commitment to supporting...
22. **Recount** – narrate, tell
The author immediately engages the reader's attention by **recounting** a personal anecdote.
23. **Skeptic(al)** – a doubter, a persistent questioner
The author presents a detailed counterargument designed to persuade even cautious **skeptics**.
24. **Substantiate** – to support with proof or evidence
The author presents detailed statistical evidence to **substantiate** his/her central claim.
25. **Vicarious** – experienced in the imagination through the feelings or actions of another
The author uses a vivid personal story that allows readers to **vicariously** understand why the issue requires strong action.

Putting it All Together: A Sample “24” Essay

College Board readers reward only the finest essays with a 24. Still, achieving this score is not an impossible task. In fact, many students are earning top scores by putting the principles outlined in this chapter into practice.

Annie Li and Swapnil Li (no relation!) both wrote perfect 24 Essays. Both attend Montgomery High School in New Jersey, and both generously granted us permission to publish their essays. Needless to say we are very proud of Annie and Swapnil!

We’re going to start with Annie’s essay. Notice how Annie weaves in vocabulary words (**bold**) and transitions (underlined) in a way that seems natural and avoids heavy-handedness. Also note how she uses repetition in the final sentences of her introduction and conclusion.

“Bad For the Birds, Bad For All of Us” (November 2016)

Living in a society where different organisms coexist, humans have a responsibility, to a certain degree, to protect other species. In their essay “Bad for the birds, bad for all of us,” John W. Fitzpatrick and George Fenwick **advocate** for the support of the U.S. government in continuing to fund conservation programs. The two build a **compelling** argument by appealing to emotions, presenting facts and statistics, and using logical reasoning.

Fitzpatrick and Fenwick begin their argument by **invoking** a sense of urgency among the readers. As they introduce the issue of declining bird populations, they further explain that it may lead to “bigger ecosystem disruptions that affect us all” (Paragraph 1). By appealing to the reader’s fears that environmental dangers are on the horizon, the authors establish the concern as an **imperative** threat to the well-being of all Americans. Consequently, the audience is more compelled to listen to their argument and to take action; the authors build the trust of their audience, as they are presenting a solution to help them and the society as a whole.

The authors continue their line of argumentation by using facts and statistics to **buttress** their claim. They express the declines of bird populations with facts: “population has plummeted 70 percent since 1970 (paragraph 2). Further, the two authors **assert** that the population of the Henslow’s Sparrow “are more than 25 times greater than they were in 1985” (paragraph 3). The increasing population is due to the implementation of the farm bill. By using statistics to express the benefits of the Conservation Reserve Program, Fitzpatrick and Fenwick establish themselves as knowledgeable researchers, rather than impractical **idealists**. Further, the readers are more likely to listen to their **cogent** argument because it is **substantiated** with statistics derived from accurate research.

Fitzpatrick and Fenwick further push for federal support of conservation programs by using logical reasoning. To illustrate that preserving bird habitats also benefits humans, they reason that conservation “yields both healthy food and vibrant ecological systems” (paragraph 8). The authors’ reasoning for support of conservation programs extends beyond helping the birds. They appeal to the readers by logically presenting that there are advantages for humans as well. As a result, the audience better understands the reasons for conservation programs and are more **compelled** to support them. Also by using logical reasoning, Fitzpatrick and Fenwick **buttress** their claims, building a sense of trustworthiness between themselves and their readers.

Fitzpatrick and Fenwick successfully voice the necessity of government funding in conservation programs. They accomplish the feat of building a convincing argument by appealing to readers’ emotions to **invoke** a sense of urgency, presenting facts and statistics to establish their **credibility** as authors, and reasoning in a logical manner to **substantiate** their claims.

Next, we're going to look at Swapnil's essay. Notice how Swapnil also weaves in vocabulary words (bold) and transitions (underlined) in a natural way. Also note how he carefully explains how each of the author's arguments will affect his readers. Finally, observe how Swapnil makes effective use of parallel structure in the final sentences of his introduction and conclusion.

"Space Technology: A Critical Investment for Our Nation's Future" (January 2017)

The technological success of our country is rooted in space exploration but the underlying reasons are often overlooked. In his article titled "Space Technology: A Critical Investment for Our Nation's Future," author Bobby Braun skillfully persuades readers of the importance of increasing NASA's federal budget so that the United States may continue to remain a pioneer in technology. Braun crafts his **cogent** argument by appealing to emotion, citing historical evidence and appealing to logic.

The author creates a persuasive argument by appealing to the emotions of the reader. Braun creates a tone of loss and dramatic sadness by mentioning the reduction of funding faced by NASA. He states, "Unfortunately, the pioneering spirit **embodied** by this **storied** agency is **endangered** as a result of **chronic** underinvestment in basic and applied research." The **implication** is that society will never again regain the "pioneering spirit" it once had. This forces the reader to consider the importance of NASA and to think of the many **beneficial** effects it has had on society. Furthermore, it prompts the reader to want to regain that lost sense of wonder and spirit by increasing funding for NASA. Thus, the author builds a persuasive argument by appealing to the emotions of the reader.

Braun continues his line of argumentation by citing historical evidence of NASA's past success. By making his readers aware of what NASA has accomplished in the past, Braun establishes NASA as being a premier organization capable of great and **unprecedented** success. Braun lists the past successes of NASA stating, "For NASA, past cutting-edge technology investment led to design and flight of the Apollo missions, the space shuttle, the international space station and a myriad of robotic explorers that allowed us to reach destinations across our solar system and peer across the universe." This long list of past missions forces the reader to consider what more NASA may be capable of doing. Braun's extensive list also intends to awe readers and convince them that if NASA has done it once, the agency can do it again given **adequate** funding. The author cites past precedent set by NASA to convince the reader of the importance of increasing the agency's funding.

Finally, to **bolster** his argument even more the author appeals to logic. Braun convinces the reader of the importance of NASA by pointing out how beneficial it is to our current society and how it logically makes sense to increase the funding. Braun points out that, "improved biomedical applications including advanced medical imaging and more nutritious infant formula, and the protective gear that keeps our military, firefighters and police safe, have all benefitted from our nation's investments in aerospace technology." The point Braun makes here is that NASA has benefitted us in many sectors of society. This allows the reader to logically understand that if NASA is so beneficial to society, why does it not receive more funding? This **discrepancy** is specifically hinted at by Braun to force the reader into agreeing with the claim that space technology should indeed receive more funding. Braun appeals to the reader's logical reasoning to further his own argument.

The author argues that space technology in the United States should receive more funding to ensure the **prosperity** of future generations of Americans and the success of our government. Braun **buttresses** his argument by appealing to emotion, citing past **precedent**, and appealing to logic.

Practice Makes Perfect

We strongly recommend that you write several practice essays. The College Board introduced the new Essay format on the March 2016 exam. Here is a list of 10 passages used since that date. All of the passages are easily available on the Internet.

1. "Viewpoint: Air-Conditioning Will Be the End of Us," by Eric Klinenberg
<http://ideas.time.com/2013/07/17/viewpoint-air-conditioning-will-be-the-end-of-us/>
2. "The Lovely Stones," by Christopher Hitchens
<http://www.vanityfair.com/culture/2009/07/hitchens200907>
3. "The North West London Blues," by Zadie Smith
<http://www.nybooks.com/daily/2012/06/02/north-west-london-blues/>
4. "Read, Kids, Read," by Frank Bruni
https://www.nytimes.com/2014/05/13/opinion/bruni-read-kids-read.html?_r=0
5. "Raise the Minimum Wage," by the Los Angeles Editorial Board
<http://www.latimes.com/opinion/editorials/la-ed-minimum-wage-increase-20130913-story.html>
6. "It's Time For Paid Family and Medical Leave To Empower Women and Modernize the Workplace," by Senator Kirsten Gillibrand
http://www.huffingtonpost.com/rep-kirsten-gillibrand/its-time-for-paid-family-and-medical-leave_b_4732451.html
7. "Bad for the Birds, Bad for All of Us," by John W. Fitzpatrick and George Fenwick
https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/bad-for-the-birds-bad-for-all-of-us/2013/08/08/d5a11a34-ff83-11e2-9a3e916de805f65d_story.html?utm_term=.9cedfb12d252
8. "Space Technology: A Critical Investment for our Nation's Future," by Bobby Braun
<http://thehill.com/opinion/op-ed/190387-space-technology-a-critical-investment-for-our-nations-future>
9. "Opinion Stew," by David Katz, *Huntington Post*, April 12, 2013
http://www.huffingtonpost.com/david-katz-md/nutrition-advice_b_3061646.html
10. "Working Less Would Provide Much to Americans," Richard Schiffman, *Washington Post*, January 27, 2012
https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/working-less-would-provide-much-to-americans/2012/01/26/gIQArhKPWQ_story.html?utm_term=.b5c7710782eb

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Larry's success has extended beyond the classroom. He is the author of widely known prep books for AP US History and SAT Vocabulary and Critical Reading. He conducts AP US History and SAT workshops for students throughout the United States.

Erica Meltzer earned her B.A. from Wellesley College and spent more than a decade tutoring privately in Boston and New York City, as well as nationally and internationally via Skype. Her experience working with students from a wide range of educational backgrounds and virtually every score level, from the third percentile to the 99th, gave her unique insight into the types of stumbling blocks students often encounter when preparing for standardized reading and writing tests.

She was inspired to begin writing her own test-prep materials in 2007, after visiting a local bookstore in search of additional practice questions for an SAT Writing student. Unable to find material that replicated the contents of the exam with sufficient accuracy, she decided to write her own. What started as a handful of exercises jotted down on a piece of paper became the basis for her first book, the original *Ultimate Guide to SAT Grammar*, published in 2011. Since that time, she has authored guides for SAT reading and vocabulary, as well as verbal guides for the ACT®, GRE®, and GMAT®. Her books have sold more than 100,000 copies and are used around the world. She lives in New York City, and you can visit her online at www.thecriticalreader.com.

SAT® Vocabulary: A New Approach is designed to help students both learn and apply key vocabulary necessary to ace the Verbal portion of the redesigned SAT. Each chapter features carefully sequenced lessons as well as guided and independent practice questions accompanied by thorough explanations.

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- Passage-Based Vocabulary
- Commonly Confused Words
- Transitional Words and Phrases
- Key Essay Vocabulary

Ideal for high school students who need to strengthen their knowledge of core academic vocabulary as well as those who need to focus on the most challenging words and concepts tested on the Verbal portion of the exam.

Larry Krieger has worked as an SAT tutor and test-prep writer since 1994. His previous books include the first three editions of *Direct Hits*, as well as *The Insider's Complete Guide to SAT® Vocabulary: the Essential 500 Words* and *SAT® Critical Reading and Vocabulary*. He has also authored widely used AP® prep books for American History, European History, and American Government.

In 2007, Erica Meltzer answered a Craigslist ad for an SAT tutor and unexpectedly found herself in the high-pressure world of Manhattan test prep. Today, she is the author of guides for the SAT®, ACT®, GRE® and GMAT®, and her work has been cited in *Teen Vogue*, *The College Solution*, and *CBS MarketWatch*. She lives in New York City, and you can visit her online at www.thecriticalreader.com.

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